13 crore in its original run, *Tumbbad* surpassed that figure in less than two weeks after release on September 13.

» A WALK DOWN MEMORY LANE

As heartwarming as it is to re-experience an old film with a new audience, the success of re-releases also seems to be reflecting an uncomfortable truth about the current slate of Hindi films—that they aren't meeting audience expectations. Akkshay Rathie, director at Aashirwad Theaters and a film exhibitor, highlights why exhibitors like him are putting yesteryear fare on the big screen. "If you look at the Hindi film release calendar this year, they are all scrambling for space on festive weekends," he says. The release strategy baffles him, given that 2023's *Jawan* was the highest grossing Hindi film of all time until *Stree 2* eclipsed it, which it did by releasing on a non-holiday weekend. At least two films—*Khel Khel Mein* and *Vedaa*—have borne the brunt of a crammed holiday release slate in 2024. "Our filmmakers really need to back their content with belief," says Rathie, "and start looking at weekends that are not cluttered. Older films are being re-released to fill that gap."

The lack of interesting new films is benefitting the likes of Imtiaz Ali who had three of his old films release in 2024: *Jab We Met, Rockstar* and *Laila Majnu*. "The phenomenon of re-releases proves that a film is permanent," he says. He compares the experience to "a date with a known lover". "There are many things one wants to watch several times because there is a beauty you want to witness again and again," he adds. Both *Rockstar* and *Laila Majnu* joined by *Tumbbad* are among the most successful re-releases this year. *Laila Majnu*, a 2018 release starring Avinash Tiwary and the then newcomer and now It girl Triptii Dimri, outdid the Rs 2.18 crore collection in its first theatrical run in just three days.



"DRIVING OUR DECISION IS NOT NOSTALGIA OR FILLING IN WEEKENDS BUT A DIVERSE AUDIENCE WE CANNOT IGNORE"

NIHARIKA BIJLI, Lead Strategist, PVR INOX Ltd



"WE ARE VERY PROUD THAT WE ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR BRINGING BACK CLASSICS TO THEATRES"

S.S. DUNGARPUR
Film Heritage Foundation

Successful re-releases are also expanding their audience base not just in metros but also elsewhere, as multiplex chains like Cinepolis and single screens jump on the bandwagon too. Cinepolis has re-released 20 films this year—some in as many as 40 cities—contributing 2.1 per cent to the total admissions and 1.4 per cent to the overall box office collections. "The resurgence of interest in classic and beloved films is also fuelled by the limited opportunities to see them again on the big screen," says Devang Sampat, MD, Cinepolis India.

This testament to the longevity of films and the audience's own ability to not forget the past has seen the phenomenon go beyond a fad to one cinemas have wholeheartedly embraced. "When we make movies, we keep in mind that they will outlast us. So we put everything into them and make sure there's no stone unturned or detail that is superficial," says Ali. "It gives films a long shelf life, and anything that has that can always potentially be re-released at a certain point for the audience to reclaim it and enjoy it." And perhaps become more cinema-literate too.

» A FESTIVE AFFAIR

The man you could credit for getting the re-release trend going, albeit in a more curated manner, is Shivendra Singh Dungarpur. Last year, his Film Heritage Foundation, a non-profit that works for film restoration and preservation, curated three retrospectives celebrating the works of Amitabh Bachchan, Dev Anand and Dilip Kumar in association with PVR INOX. With nominally priced tickets, many of the films ran to sold-out shows, as audiences sang along, cheered and whistled. The Foundation has also hosted standalone screenings of classics like *Mahal* and *Sholay* in Regal cinema in Mumbai this year, attracting a thousand people. "A lot of the young generation who have never experienced the era, films or actors find it cool to see them," says Dungarpur. In December, FHF celebrates the centenary of actor-filmmaker Raj Kapoor with a festival of his films. Also in the pipeline is a festival on the legend Tapan Sinha this year and Guru Dutt the next. "We are very proud of the Foundation that we are responsible for bringing back classics into theatres, the way they should be seen, and making old films popular and available," says Dungarpur.

Meanwhile, Rohini Kapur Alva is all set to watch *Karan Arjun* for the fourth time in cinemas. This time, the venue will be Sterling and she will have her husband for company. "I will carry a whistle, because I cannot whistle," she says. "I will see if I can carry some *chhutta* with me [to throw on the screen]." It may be 2024 but Kapur Alva is sticking to the 1990s social cinema code to enjoy one of her favourites. ■